

was a freebie and did not align with the party's ideology. But the party benefitted in the polls and other states are also copying this. Now, former MP CM Kamal Nath of the Congress claims that it was his idea. If this is indeed a form of freebie, why is the BJP implementing it?

A: What stopped Kamal Nath from implementing this scheme during his 15 months in power? If it was his scheme, what prevented him from implementing it? My party never stopped me from implementing the 'Behna' scheme. We started the 'Ladli Laxmi' scheme in 2006 when I became Chief Minister. There were no elections at that time. There was a significant difference in the birth rate of boys and girls in the state. In MP, only 912 girls were born for every 1,000 boys. There was discrimination between sons and daughters, which was painful. I felt that just giving speeches wouldn't be enough, so I designed a scheme where the birth of a daughter would be considered a blessing. The thought was that if a daughter is born rich, parents would not hesitate to give birth to her.

36 | RK: This is your first interview after moving from Bhopal to Delhi. So, was the Chief Minister's position in Bhopal better, or does being Union Agriculture Minister suit you better?

A: It doesn't matter what position you are in; what is important is how you perform in that position. When I was in Madhya Pradesh [as CM], I was dedicated day and night to serving the people of the state. Now, as PM Modi has entrusted me with the task of agriculture and rural development, my life's mission is to do the job with full dedication. I don't see any difference; I was working hard there, and I am doing the same here.

RK: You've talked about problems and their solutions. But implementing them is difficult. Your political stature gives us hope that you can accomplish this difficult task...

A: The PM is incredibly dedicated to the welfare of farmers, and various schemes have been designed for this purpose. I want to give an example... natural farming... if agriculture is to become more profitable, and if the land is to remain productive for future generations to produce fruits, vegetables, and grains, then we have to gradually prepare the country in that direction. We must work together with all states because crops will only grow in the states. This is very important, and that's why it is essential to work together with all the states. The Centre doesn't have separate land where Shivraj Singh Chouhan can per-



“Agriculture is primarily a state subject. The central government sets the MSP and makes purchases”

form miracles. Therefore, we are holding discussions with the agriculture ministers of different states. Their problems are being brought to light, and we are solving them.

For me, this is a mission. Agriculture is and always will be the backbone of the Indian economy. And the soul and lifeblood of agriculture are the farmers. To us, farmers are like Gods, and serving them is like worshipping God. I am fortunate to have been given this responsibility by the PM. Every moment of my life is spent figuring out how we can develop farming, agriculture, and villages. The meaning of life is not just to occupy a post, but to work while being in that position. **BT**

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